They parked their bicycles at number 1 Rue Royale, where the German Employment Office was housed.

Slightly out of breath, she followed him up the stairs to the second floor. The interior surprised her with its grandeur. A chandelier suspended from the ceiling cast delicate light. Below it, a white and black marble fireplace anchored the room, its mantelpiece adorned with a gold-framed mirror. Wooden panels lined the lower walls; tapestry covered the upper.

“Have you made the arrangements I asked for?” Maître Mallon asked, arms tight at his sides.

“The upfront advance has been paid to Madame Virginie LeBlanc, as requested. And we’ve found a suitable factory outside of a big city,” the man behind the desk replied. He turned to Léa and asked, “Madame Cotillard, do you have any questions?”

“No,” she said quietly, wondering why the money wasn’t going to Rose.

“Very good.” He stamped the papers and returned them to Maître Mallon. “One of my men requested a visit to see a sick family member in Berlin, so I’ve arranged for him to act as an escort to Paris, then on to Germany. All the tickets are in the envelope.” He tapped a metal bell on his desk. A man in uniform opened a side door and saluted the man at the desk.

Maître Mallon placed a hand at the edge of Léa’s elbow as if to reassure her. “Rose wanted the money to go to Virginie. She’ll explain it all to you at the station.”

The man at the desk stood. “We’ll take over from here.” He signaled to the soldier to escort Léa out the door.

Léa had the strange sense of the walls closing in on her and her legs went weak. Maître Mallon kissed her on both cheeks.

“You’ll do fine,” he said, seeming to sense her doubt. “I have full confidence in you. I’ve arranged everything as well as possible. Rose will tell you more at the station. Goodbye, Léa, and be strong for you and Rose.”

She just barely managed to utter a goodbye before the German soldier escorted her down the stairs and outside to a waiting car. Only after she was in the back seat and the door closed did she think to ask what he meant by having arranged everything for the best. She pushed away her doubts. There was no turning back. She had signed the papers, committed herself, and—with a sudden clarity—she realized that this decision would define the rest